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Johnson angles for control of CHA

Mayor's feud with housing authority leadership adds to ongoing political turmoil at city agencies

By Alice Yin and Talia Soglin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Mayor Brandon Johnson's 15-month leadership dilemma at Chicago Public Schools was finally put to rest a week ago, with the approval of its next CEO.

That's hardly the end of the issues facing the freshman mayor when it comes to appointing top bosses at the city's most important sister agencies, however. His bureaucratic beef with another government board, the Chicago Housing Authority, soared to new levels when he publicly angled to usurp the board's new CEO the same week.

And with the Chicago Transit Authority lacking a permanent leader for more than a year now, Johnson's hesitation to appoint the agency's popular interim president has bewildered some transit advocates and members of City Council.

The turmoil across the three agencies comes less than a year out from a potential Johnson reelection bid and could fester into a campaign-trail albatross for the freshmen mayor, whom opponents hope to paint as an inexperienced executive. But he continues to argue that dissent is not dysfunction.

"I know you all remember those days when you had rubber stamp City Councils, and you didn't have

this type of consternation," Johnson told reporters last month. "You know where the noise was, though? It was in the streets of Chicago."

He was not-so-subtly poking at former Mayor Rahm Emanuel, who oversaw the largest closure of public schools in U.S. history and triggered the beginnings of a formidable progressive movement that eventually helped elect Johnson.

And as it so happens, Johnson's biggest adversary on the CHA Board of Commissioners, Matthew Brewer, was appointed by Emanuel more than a decade ago but has since become interim leader of the nation's third-largest public housing agency.

In an internal memo on Thursday, Brewer toned down an earlier



Mayor Brandon Johnson, right, talks with Ald. Walter Burnett, 27th, left, and Ald. Jason Ervin, 28th, during a City Council meeting in January 2025 at City Hall. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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Five of the six Sorch siblings, Steve Sorch, clockwise from top left, Sandra Brown, Kris Sorch, Patti Parker and Sue Sabo, sit on the front steps of the Bridgeport home where they grew up. The home has been in their family for over 100 years. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

'This house has known us, kept us, and loved us'

The Sorch family has lived in a house in Chicago's Bridgeport neighborhood for more than a century. Now it's time to go

By Gregory Royal Pratt | Chicago Tribune

When Joseph Slajchert first bought a workers cottage at 29th and Emerald, the automobile was on its way to replace the horse and buggy.

But it wasn't quite there yet.

The year was 1910. A black-and-white photo from around that time in Bridgeport shows five children wearing their Sunday best on the front steps, the boys in dapper caps.

Generations of the Slajchert family stayed in the home for another 116 years, through two World Wars, global pandemics, an endless series of tragic fashion trends, the rise of the Internet and the onset of self-driving cars.

"It's pretty special to have what we had for all those years, many, many years, and we're very, very lucky."

— **PATTI PARKER**, Sorch family member who grew up in the house in Bridgeport



Patti Parker holds a photo of her grandparents Božo and Agnes Sorch standing on the home's steps.

Now the family is saying goodbye and selling the property after the home's last matriarch, Antoinette "Toni" Sorch, died last summer. She was 91.

It's a natural next step for the family and the home, but for the family's descendants, it's bittersweet. Antoinette Sorch and her husband, Stanley, raised six children in the five-bedroom workers cottage. The parents slept in the living room. From their kids, 15 grandchildren, 11 great-grandchildren and one great-great-grandchild grew to know its walls.

"I know it's just a building and home is where your mom is and she's not here anymore, but it's pretty special," daughter Patti Sorch Parker said recently from the family kitchen. "It's pretty special to have what we had for all those years, many, many years, and we're very, very lucky."

The family has spent the past few months working through the sale and processing memories. Antoinette's granddaughter, Stephanie Sorch, who has a tattoo of the home on her arm, wrote an essay about the home that she read at Antoinette's funeral, saying the "house on Emerald Avenue is saturated with the lives and history of my family."

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Trump delivers fiery threat

President again orders Iran to open strait; US rescues 2nd pilot

By Matthew Lee,
Bassem Mroue,
Konstantin Toropin
and Samy Magdy
ASSOCIATED PRESS

TEHRAN, Iran — President Donald Trump on Sunday made expletive-laden new threats to escalate strikes on Iran and its infrastructure if it doesn't open the Strait of Hormuz by his deadline, after American forces rescued an aviator whose Iran-downed plane fell behind enemy lines.

A defiant Iran struck infrastructure targets in neighboring Gulf Arab countries, challenged the U.S. account of the rescue and threatened to restrict another heavily used waterway in the region, the Bab el-Mandeb Strait off the Arabian Peninsula.

In a social media post, Trump vowed to hit Iran's power plants and bridges and said the country would be "living in Hell" if the Strait of Hormuz, crucial for global trade, isn't opened by Tuesday. He ended with "Praise be to Allah."

Trump has issued such deadlines before but extended them when mediators have claimed progress toward ending the war, which has killed thousands, shaken global markets and spiked fuel prices in just over five weeks.

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INSIDE

Leo urges peace at Easter Mass

Pope Leo XIV celebrated his first Easter as pontiff with a call Sunday to lay down arms and seek peace to global conflicts through dialogue, but he departed from a tradition of listing the world's woes by name. **Nation & World, B1**

Illini: 'We were just special'

As the Illini men's basketball team walked off the Final Four court Saturday night in Indianapolis, the mass of orange-clad fans gave their team one last goodbye. "It didn't feel like we lost, honestly," wing Andrej Stojaković said. **Sports, C1**

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